

A mutiny in the capital by Bangladesh's key border force worries India and puts the new Hasina Government in a vulnerable position

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# Tremors IN DHAKA

| By Saurabh Shukla |

**T**he siege in Dhaka following a mutiny by the soldiers of the Bangladesh Rifles (BDR), the country's border security force, has ominous implications for a country struggling to get its act together after a long spell of political uncertainty. The standoff came barely two months after a thumping win for

Sheikh Hasina in the elections held in Bangladesh in December 2008 and just when things seemed to be looking up. For the Bangladesh prime minister, it was a close brush as it was only a day earlier that she had gone to the Bangladesh Rifles headquarters for a parade, and a day later, on February 25, the soldiers were up in arms going on a shooting spree that killed several officers and wounded many.

Diplomatic sources in Dhaka said that the trouble started when some junior commissioned officers of the BDR confronted the top brass about not raising the issue of pay parity with the army with Hasina. As the siege looked to escalate, Hasina personally took charge of the negotiations, offering an amnesty to the rebel soldiers.

While the crisis may have blown over, the standoff did damage Hasina's fragile Government. It also raises questions about the impact of the discontent among Bangladesh's armed forces on the security situation on the Indo-Bangla border. In the past too, the 70,000-strong and trigger-happy BDR has been plagued with rampant indiscipline. Eight years ago, 16 Indian Border Security Force (BSF) soldiers were killed by the BDR following a minor altercation, and then in April 2005, a BSF assistant commandant and a sol-